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THEATRE ARTS

SCRIPTWRITING

Writing the One-Act Play

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

A practical course in the form most student festivals actually ask for: one place, one situation, twenty-five minutes, and an ending that changes something.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- the single situation
- entrances and exits
- the turn
- the ending
- format

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One act does one thing

A one-act play is not a short three-act play. It is a single action, in one place, in real time or near it, with a small cast, that begins when a situation can no longer stay as it is and ends when it has changed. The audience should be able to say what happened in one sentence, and that sentence should not be "two people talked".

The commonest failure is a scene that is well written and has no pressure: two characters exchange information, reveal a secret, and part. Information is not action. A character must want something that another character can give or refuse, and the refusal must cost something.

Build the situation before the dialogue

Answer four questions on paper. Who wants what? Who or what is in the way? Why now, and not yesterday? What happens if they fail? If the answer to the third question is "nothing in particular", you have a scene rather than a play.

Then decide the shape: the arrival that changes the balance, the attempt, the reversal, the last attempt, and the cost. Most one-acts run on two or three attempts, not one. The second attempt is where the writing usually becomes a play, because the character now knows the first one failed.

Entrances and exits are your structure

In a one-act, every entrance changes the pressure and every exit leaves someone alone with the consequences. A third character who arrives to deliver a message and leaves is a device; a third character who arrives because they cannot stay away is a plot. Use the door as a decision, not transport.

The ending should be inevitable and surprising

The ending is not the solution to the problem. It is the moment the audience sees what the problem has cost. Leave the room in a different condition from the one it was in when the lights came up: a promise broken, a person gone, a thing said that cannot be unsaid. A final speech that explains the play is usually the playwright losing confidence in the scene.

Format is a courtesy to the people who have to produce you

Use the standard layout: character names in capitals, dialogue under them, stage directions in italics or brackets and kept to what can be seen or heard, a title page with your name and a contact, and page numbers. A director reading forty entries in a competition will decide in the first page whether the script is producible. Give them a clean page.

The read-through test

A draft is not finished until it has been read aloud by people who are not you. Give each reader a character, sit them round a table, and listen without interrupting. You will learn three things in twenty minutes: where the audience laughs when you did not intend it, where they lose the thread, and where the play is better than you thought. Write nothing down during the reading; the things worth keeping will still be there afterwards, and the rest is noise.

Then cut ten per cent. Almost every first draft of a one-act is ten per cent too long, and the ten per cent is usually at

the start of scenes: the greetings, the settling, the explanation of what the audience can already see. Cut the first two speeches of every scene and read it again. If it still makes sense, you have found the play.

Finally, check the stage directions against the budget. A one-act that needs a working tap, a fire and a car is a one-act that will not be produced by a student company. Write for two chairs, one door and a lamp, and let the writing do the rest; the best one-acts in the repertory are built out of almost nothing.

The title, the cast list and the first page

A competition reader sees the title page, the cast list and the first page before deciding whether to read on. Make the title do work: "The Last Bus" tells the reader more than "A Play in One Act". Make the cast list honest: five characters, not "Crowd". Make the first page begin inside the situation, not before it.

Do not open with a stage direction that describes the weather, the furniture and the history of the family. Open with a person doing something they cannot easily stop doing. The audience will learn where they are from what they do.

Exercises

1. Write the one-sentence action of three published one-acts you have seen, then write the one-sentence action of your own draft. If yours cannot be stated, rewrite the situation.
2. Draft a fifteen-minute play with two characters and one door. Nothing may enter or leave except through it.
3. Take a scene you have written and cut the first page. Read it aloud. Most first pages are the playwright warming up.

Where to read more

Aristotle, Poetics (c. 335 BCE)

William Archer, Play-Making (1912)

Lajos Egri, The Art of Dramatic Writing (1946)

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